

DECISIVE MOMENT June 28, 1914 10:50 a.m.

The Assassination at Sarajevo

The spark that caused the European tinderbox to ignite into World War I was lit in the Bosnian capital of Sarajevo. The assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, triggered a series of reactions that would lead to a full-scale European war within five weeks, a war that soon spread around the world.

The archduke and his wife Sofia were making an official visit to Sarajevo to inspect military maneuvers. Austria-Hungary had occupied the Turkish province of Bosnia-Herzegovina since 1878 and fully annexed it in 1908. Neighboring Serbia resented this, as the province was mainly populated by Serbs, so relations between the two states were tense.

As the royal couple drove to an official reception at the town hall, a bomb was thrown into their car. It bounced off the rear canopy and exploded under the car behind, injuring two royal aides and 18 others. After the reception, the archduke changed his route out of the town but on the way, his driver took a wrong turning and halted. By chance, a group of conspirators involved in the earlier incident but not detained by the police were loitering there. One of them, Gavrilo Princip, a 19-year-old student, leaped onto the car's running board and shot the royal couple at point-blank range, hitting

the archduke in the neck and his wife in the abdomen. They both died within a few minutes.

It was clear that Princip had not acted alone. He and his five fellow assassins were members of the Black Hand, a secret nationalist society led by Colonel Dragutin Dimitrijevic, head of Serbia's military intelligence. Austria-Hungary then accused the Serbian government of complicity in the assassination. It also asked its ally, Germany, for support against Serbia. When this was confirmed, Austria-Hungary issued an ultimatum on July 23 that would have effectively ended Serbian independence. Serbia's reply was received in the Austrian capital just two minutes short of the 48-hour deadline. It had agreed to almost all of Austria's demands, but also appealed to Russia for help and offered to refer the dispute to the International Court. The reply was rejected. The next day, July 26, Austria-Hungary mobilized its forces, declaring war on Serbia on July 28. The countdown to war had begun.

Arrest

Soldiers arrest 19-year-old Gavrilo Princip after the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his wife, Sofia, in Sarajevo.

“The lamps are going out all over Europe. We shall not see them lit again **in our lifetime.**”

SIR EDWARD GREY, BRITISH FOREIGN SECRETARY, AUGUST 3, 1914

